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12/3/25

Genre as a Mode of Thought and Tradition

Early Modern writers inherited and reshaped classical and medieval ideas and literary forms. Among these, *Paradise Lost* stands out as an attempt to enter the epic tradition while transforming it. Milton incorporates the format of classical epic inherited from Virgil while also adopting the theological architecture of Dante's medieval Christian poem. Yet, Milton did not copy his predecessors' work but transformed the genre by rejecting classical ideals of heroism and infusing the epic with psychological, domestic, and theological depth appropriate to the Early Modern world. In *Paradise Lost*, Milton combines Virgil's epic format with Dante's theological symbolism to create what would be known as an Early Modern Christian epic centered on interior conflict, free will, and the complexities of domestic relationships.

Milton's similarities with Virgil's *Aeneid* are unmistakable and deliberate. He adopts the format of the classical epic only to redirect it toward new moral and theological ends. Milton adapts Virgil's epic form to explore the biblical history of the Genesis and humanist ideas about the individual. Milton's invocation is very similar to Virgil's. Virgil begins: "I sing of arms and the man" and "Muse, tell me the cause..." (*Aeneid* 1.1, 1.7). This classical opening centers the epic on war, empire, and nationality. Milton similarly calls upon a Muse, but his invocation seeks spiritual enlightenment rather than imperial celebration. He appeals to the "Heavenly Muse" who taught humanity divine truth, and he declares his purpose "to justify the ways of God to men" (*Paradise Lost* 1.6, 1.26). The classical form remains intact, but the goal of the poem is mutated. Milton's epic is not imperial but instead theological, not to celebrate but to explain. The epic hero is subject to similar reworkings. Aeneas, traditionally known as Pius Aeneas, is defined by

his duty to the gods and his destiny. By contrast, Milton gives Satan many superficial features of the classical hero, grandeur, resolve, rhetorical expertise, but exposes how these virtues collapse when detached from obedience and God. When Milton compares Satan's rising form to the sun burning through mist (*Paradise Lost* 1.594), he deliberately echoes Virgil's heroic similes, but the effect is ineffective: Satan's heroism is still only on the surface. Milton uses classical epic style to critique classical heroic ideals, suggesting that unchecked ambition is morally destructive. Milton's adaptation of the council scene likewise demonstrates his transformation of classical style. Virgil's divine council in *Aeneid* Book 1 asserts the gods' role in directing Rome's destiny. Milton's council in Pandemonium, similarly, becomes a parody of misleading rhetoric. Instead of wisdom, it displays vanity, flattery, and persuasion manipulation, an early Modern suspicion of political rhetoric. Similarly, his listing of fallen angels parallels Virgil's catalogue of heroes in Book 7, but Milton's list exposes the spiritual emptiness of the fallen angels rather than celebrating national lineage. In all these ways, Milton uses Virgil's epic conventions but transforms their function to suit a more theological and moral epic.

If Virgil gives Milton his epic format, Dante gives him a theological and symbolic framework to build from. Milton draws from *The Divine Comedy* in his depiction of Hell, in his understanding of beauty, and in his commitment to representing free will as the core of human identity. Yet Milton adopts Dante in a distinctly Early Modern direction, shifting from medieval allegories to a greater emphasis on individual psychology and interior experience. Both Dante and Milton treat landscape as a moral structure. Dante's hell, with its carefully ordered circles, expresses divine justice visibly. Milton's Hell in *Paradise Lost* is similarly infused with theological meaning, though he forgoes Dante's strict architecture for something more psychological than physical.

“No light, but rather darkness visible

Served only to discover sights of woe,

Regions of sorrow, doleful shades, where peace

And rest can never dwell, hope never comes” (Paradise Lost 1.63-1.67)

“No light”, “woe”, and “sorrow” show the inward desolation of the fallen angels, and this is what Milton emphasizes over physical pain. Milton inherits Dante’s idea that location embodies moral condition but reshapes it into a more introspective representation. Milton’s treatment of beauty likewise reflects Dante’s influence on Milton. Dante’s Beatrice represents divine illumination, raising Dante toward the source of spiritual truth. Milton gives Eve a beauty that similarly appears divine. Yet while Beatrice’s beauty is wholly uplifting, Eve’s beauty is bound to her human vulnerability. Her grace becomes intertwined with her temptation, revealing her human vulnerability. This contrast marks Milton’s departure from Dante’s allegories of beauty and his embrace of Renaissance humanism, which treats individuals, even idealized ones, as capable of moral failure. Free will provides another crucial link between Milton and Dante. Dante presents sin as the visible consequence of freely chosen desires: the damned in *Inferno* are punished by the size of their own wills. Milton makes this principle central, asserting that humans were created “sufficient to have stood though free to fall” (Paradise Lost 3.99). Through these adaptations, Milton honors the medieval Christian epic while reshaping it into a narrative centered around personal struggle and responsibility.

Although Milton inherited much of his style from Virgil and Dante, *Paradise Lost* ultimately invents a new genre of its own, deeply intertwined with Renaissance humanism and Early Modern qualms about persuasion, free will, and internal conflict. Milton transforms epic

grandeur from the physical world to the psychological, domestic, and rhetorical struggles that define human experience. Most important among Milton's innovations is his portrayal of inner struggle. Satan's admission that "myself am hell" encapsulates a psychological struggle within the fallen angel, not just a physical location (*Paradise Lost* 4.75). Adam and Eve also struggle internally, Adam struggling to obey God against his idolization of Eve, and Eve's want for autonomy and wisdom. Classical epic heroes act, while Milton's think, doubt, and desire. Milton also forms a new genre by making the domestic, Adam and Eve's relationship, the center of the story. Instead of kings, generals, and armies, *Paradise Lost* offers conversations, emotions, and decisions of a married couple. For example, in Book 9 Eve's proposal to work separately and Adam's reluctant agreement was a turning point with exceptional consequences, a choice that seemed harmless, between a married couple, but initiated a sequence of tragic events. Furthermore, rhetoric, not warfare, becomes the poem's primary mode of conflict. Satan's persuasion of Eve in Book 9 is the central "battle" of the poem, but instead of sword and bows it was conducted through flattery and twisted logic. Eve's response to Satan, shaped by her desire to grow in wisdom, demonstrates the vulnerability of human reason when confronted with seductive rhetoric. Through these innovations, Milton reshapes the epic to reflect Early Modern moral and psychological concerns.

Milton's *Paradise Lost* stands at the intersection between classical, medieval and Early Modern literary traditions. By adopting and transforming Virgil's epic format and Dante's Christian-based theological symbolism, and by infusing his narrative with the rhetorical, psychological, and humanist concerns of his own era, Milton creates a new kind of epic. A genre of epic that focuses more on interior struggle than external conquest. Through these transformations, *Paradise Lost* becomes not merely a continuation of epic tradition but a

reinvention of it, expressing the Early Modern belief that the greatest battles are fought not on fields of war but within the human heart.

Works Cited

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